Thomas Jefferson or Woodrow Wilson.

The competitive free enterprise system has given us the greatest standard of living in the world, produced generation after generation of technical wizards who consistently lead the world in invention and innovation, and has provided unlimited opportunities enabling industrious Americans from the most humble of backgrounds to climb to the top of the ladder of success.

By 1960, I realized the real enemy wasn't big business, it was big government.

Following the election that year, I began to get more and more invitations from the Republicans to speak at their dinners and fundraisers and they more or less adopted me as one of their own even though I was still a Democrat. When a lot of the nation's most prominent Democrats got behind socialized medicine, I started speaking out against it. If we didn't head it off, I said, "one of these days you and I are going to spend our sunset years telling our children and our children's children what it once was like in America when men were free."

In 1962, while campaigning for Nixon during his unsuccessful attempt to unseat California's Democratic governor, a tax-and-spend liberal named Edmund G. (Pat) Brown, I made it official: I spoke to a Republican fund-raising event near my home in Pacific Palisades and a woman in the audience stood up in the middle of my speech and asked me: "Have you reregistered as a Republican yet?"

"Well, no, I haven't yet," I said, "but I intend to."

"I'm a registrar," she said, and walked down the center aisle through the audience and placed a registration form in front of me. I signed it and became a Republican, then said to the audience, "Now, where was I?"